

Yaxuan (Stella) Mao

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SUMMARY OF QUALIFICATIONS

- **Proficient in User Experience Research (UXR):** User research, user testing, co-design, A/B test, usability testing, survey design, diary studies, thematic analysis.
- **Design tools:** Adobe Creative Suite (Illustrator, Premiere, After Effects), UE5, Unity, Figma, Maya, etc.
- **Strong Programming Skills:** Python (Advanced), C++ (Advanced), JavaScript (Advanced), CSS (Advanced), HTML (Advanced), Arduino (Advanced), OpenCV (Advanced), OpenFramework (Advanced), C# (Intermediate), Processing (Intermediate), SQL (Intermediate), D3.js (Intermediate), ROS (Intermediate).
- **Five years of proven leadership experience** with effective communication skills, teamwork, and project management as demonstrated through entrepreneurship, academic project, student assignment, and extracurricular activities.

EDUCATION

University of Washington, Seattle, WA **GPA: 4.0/4.0** *Expected June 2027*

Master of Science, Human Centered Design and Engineering (HCDE)

- Relevant Coursework: User-centered Design, Design Process Resilience, Experimental Research Methods

City University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong, China

Sep. 2020 - Jun. 2024

Bachelor of Science, Creative Media *Cum Laude (Top 10%)*

- Relevant Coursework: User Experience Research and Design, Visual Communication (UI/UX), Interdisciplinary Research, Data Structure, AI Game Programming, Algorithm, Multi-modal Interface, Computer Vision

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

University of Washington | User Research Assistant

October 2025 - Present

- **Designed and developed a high-fidelity robot prototype** to facilitate participatory design, engineering features that enable the collection of real-time interaction data for **quantitative analysis**.
- **Conducted co-design workshops** with K-12 students and teachers to investigate strategies for integrating social robots into educational settings, translating stakeholder feedback into **design iterations**.

Digital China | UX Researcher Intern (AI Team)

April - August 2025

- Conducted **human-in-the-loop** evaluation of LLM agents in enterprise HR scenarios, identifying key usability bottlenecks in generated responses.
- **Collaborated with engineers** to refine model prompts based on user intent analysis, resulting in a **54% improvement** in scenario-specific response accuracy (**32% to 86%**).

Tsinghua University | Part-time Researcher

April - October 2025

- Applied a **mixed-methods approach**, combining **qualitative insights (user interviews, thematic coding)** with **quantitative data (usability and performance metrics)** to inform interface design.
- Designed and built a **robot prototype** by replicating a GitHub open-source design and enhancing it with custom **Arduino** functionality, increasing reading focus (**+26.7%**) and engagement (**+15.9%**) in user testing.

Youth Incubator | UI/UX Designer

June - October 2024

- **Design and implement UI components** using WebPress, HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, improving website usability and visual appeal for **over 1,500 monthly visitors**.
- Maintained brand and design consistency by **updating over 30+ UI elements** to align with new course offerings and refreshed organizational branding, resulting in a **15% increase in user engagement on key pages**.

BiWell | User Researcher

June 2023 - March 2025

- Led **co-design workshops** with children, guardians, and dentists to capture diverse perspectives on pediatric dental experiences and anxiety triggers.
- Conducted **qualitative analysis** of workshop data, identifying key emotional and behavioral themes that informed the design of a VR-based intervention system.
- **Prototyped** an immersive VR experience in **Unreal Engine**, improving children's comfort and engagement.

SeeWall Limited | Co-Founder & Product Designer

August 2021 - February 2023

- Led **user-centered research** and **iterative design** to develop assistive tools for visually impaired users, conducting interviews and usability tests with **50+ participants**.
- Translated key insights into two inclusive products—an audio-guided navigation app and a wearable obstacle-detection belt—that **boosted navigation accuracy by 28%** and **reduced user stress and hesitation by 35%**, enhancing both usability and emotional confidence.

PUBLICATION LIST

- P1 **Yaxuan Mao**, Yanheng Li, Duo Gong, Pengcheng An, Yuhan Luo. 2025. "Can I Decorate My Teeth With Diamonds?": Exploring Multi-Stakeholder Perspectives on Using VR to Reduce Children's Dental Anxiety. In *Proceedings of the 28th ACM Conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing (CSCW)*.
- P2 Katie Xue, **Yaxuan Mao**, Junnan Yu, Yuhan Luo. 2025. Toward Interactive Reading: Co-designing with Adolescents to Explore Opportunities for Overcoming Reading Challenges. In *Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Interaction Design and Children (IDC '25)* WiP.
- P3 Yanheng Li, Long Bai, **Yaxuan Mao**, Xuening Peng, Zehao Zhang, Antoni B Chan, Jixing Li, Xin Tong, RAY LC. 2024. Affecting Audience Valence and Arousal in 360 Immersive Environments: How Powerful Neural Style Transfer Is? In *Proceedings of the International Conference on Human-Computer Interaction (HCI)*.
- P4 Yanheng Li*, **Yaxuan Mao***, Ray LC. 2023. Communicating Failure Recovery with Robotic Body Movement. In *Proceedings of the 21th IEEE International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA)*, workshop. [Published]
- P5 Yanheng Li, Long Bai, **Yaxuan Mao**, Hongliang Ren, Yu Qiao, Xin Tong and Ray LC. 2023. Rethinking Pain Communication of Patients with Alzheimer's Disease through E-textile Interaction Design. In *Proceedings of Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*.
- P6 Yanheng Li, Long Bai, **Yaxuan Mao**, Xuening Peng, Zehao Zhang, Xin Tong, Ray LC. 2023. The Exploration and Evaluation of Generating Affective 360-Panoramic VR Environments Through Neural Style Transfer. In *Proceedings of the 30th IEEE International Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces (VR)*.
- P7 Yanheng Li, Luoying Lin, Xinyan Li, **Yaxuan Mao** and RAY LC. 2023. "Nice to meet you!": Expressing Emotions with Movement Gestures and Textual Content in Automatic Handwriting Robots. In *Proceedings of the 18th ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human Robot Interaction (HRI)*, late-breaking report.